



Calling the shots: Salima Tete, now at the helm of India's midfield, was appointed captain of the Indian women's team in May 2024. HOCKEY INDIA

much have I improved over the week, month, quarter or even the year? Which areas is the coach focusing on? Where am I not improving? Where do I stand in terms of nutrition, physiology, biomechanics, VO2 max, speed, and recovery?

Once you develop this environment, the player feels like she is part of an ecosystem that is more conducive and supportive rather than stressful.

You have had a chance to not only cover the Hockey India League as a broadcaster but also observe many Indian girls who have performed well. Who has impressed you the most?

There were around six girls who were not in the core group but are knocking on the door. The selectors and I have to make a decision now. Once these girls are inducted into the national coaching set-up, we

have to provide them with match experience.

If you look at the teams competing in the Olympics and World Cup, their players have a minimum of 50 caps. The HIL plays a role in providing that experience, helping us gauge how well they can gel with foreign and Indian players. There is the pressure of performance, the pressure of making the team, the pressure from the franchise, and the pressure of performing in front of an audience from over 150 countries. If a player can handle this pressure, it means she is ready to wear Indian colours.

Generally, I don't reveal names, but I can still say that Sonam, Annu, and Jyoti Singh are some players who have shown potential.

What was the idea behind making Salima Tete the captain as India women's hockey entered its rebuilding phase?

When I took over, Savita Punia was the captain. She is an amazing goalkeeper with an incredible personality. She has everything it takes to lead the team. But is it

necessary to wear the armband to be a leader? I don't think so. A leader doesn't require a title.

(P. R.) Sreejesh, Savita, and Dhanraj Pillay are born leaders. It's not up to me to make them leaders — they already are. If something goes wrong in a game, the captain gets the yellow card. This is why I made Manpreet (Singh) the captain of the men's team instead of Sreejesh when I joined in 2018.

I had to convince Hockey India back then, and they eventually understood. If a player makes a mistake, I can afford Manpreet getting a yellow card and sitting out. But I cannot afford my second-choice goalkeeper being on the pitch for five, 10, or 25 minutes in place of my first-choice goalkeeper.

I also wanted someone who leads through performance on the pitch. If you are delivering what the team needs, you have every right to ask other players to step up. If that isn't the case, others will challenge your authority. Salima, with her performances over the last three to four years, has now taken on that